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Imagined Noncommunities: National Indifference as a Category of Analysis

Tara Zahra

Last Christmas I convinced my father to dig up some old family letters. My grandfather, a Jewish taxi driver from New York, served in the U.S. Army in Germany during World War II. He wrote weekly letters home to my grandmother, and I hoped they might serve as a source for my new research project. In any event, I was curious about what my grandfather had to say about Nazi Germany. I was quickly disappointed, however. It turns out that my grandfather was more interested in declaring his undying love for his “fatty” at home and promising gifts of silk stockings than in analyzing political conditions in wartime Europe. The letters might as well have been written from Brooklyn as from Bavaria. The only proof I have that my grandfather set foot on German soil at all is a photo of him leaning against a wall in Bubenheim, in the Rhineland (population 446) in 1945. On the back of the photo he wrote, “Bubenheim, Germany. Plenty close to hell.”

Was my grandfather indifferent to the political dramas unfolding around him? He died when I was eight years old, so I have no way of knowing. But reading those letters pushed me to think about indifference to politics and the broader issues it poses for historians. Indifference raises particular challenges for social and cultural historians—those of us explicitly interested in uncovering the experiences of nonelites and convinced that ordinary lives have something important to tell us about society, politics, culture, and historical change. What if our subjects seem to shrug their shoulders at the questions that interest us? Does it mean we need to ask different questions? Or can apparent indifference itself be a significant clue about the past?

This article explores the potential of national indifference as a category of analysis in the history of modern central and eastern Europe. Since the birth of modern mass political movements in the nineteenth century, European nationalists across the political spectrum have lamented the failure of their constituents to respond to the siren-call of national awakening. In 1908, Czech nationalists in northern Bohemia complained, “On the language frontier we wrestle for every inch of soil, and we must not only fight with the Germans, but also with renegades and with Czech apathy and national indifference.”¹

But while national indifference has long been an obsession of nationalist activists in east central Europe, it has only recently become a subject of historical research. Several historians of east central Europe have re-

I thank Pieter Judson, Jeremy King, the participants at the 2008 Conference “Sites of Indifference to Nation in Habsburg Central Europe” at the University of Alberta, and the anonymous referees for *Slavic Review* for their helpful feedback on earlier drafts of this essay.

1. “Vyroční zpráva národní jednoty severočeské” (1908), 4.

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cently made national indifference or ambiguity in eastern Europe a central focus of their work.² But what is national indifference exactly, and why has it attracted historians' attention? How have forms and expressions of national indifference changed over time? How does the concept of indifference intersect with other methodological approaches that attempt to see beyond the nation-state, such as regional history, borderland studies, and transnational history? And finally, what methodological challenges face researchers who attempt to excavate the history of national indifference? Making indifference visible, I argue, enables historians to better understand the limits of nationalization and thereby challenges the nationalist narratives, categories, and frameworks that have traditionally dominated the historiography of eastern Europe.

Indifference and the Denationalization of History

Twenty-five years ago, anthropologists began to reflect on the colonialist origins of their discipline. In a seminal 1973 article, Diane Lewis wrote, "Since anthropology emerged along with the expansion of Europe and the colonization of the non-Western world, anthropologists found themselves participants in the colonial system which organized relationships between Westerners and non-Westerners."³ This critique provoked decades of soul-searching, through which anthropologists sought to decolonize both their research strategies and their theoretical assumptions. Historians are currently in the midst of a similar process, as we face up to our discipline's record as a faithful accomplice in nation-building projects. Recent interest in national indifference among historians of east central Europe is inextricable from this broader movement to "rescue History from the Nation."⁴

2. Gary Cohen drew historians' attention to national indifference almost thirty years ago by highlighting the social dynamics of national affiliation in Prague. See Gary B. Cohen, *The Politics of Ethnic Survival: Germans in Prague, 1861–1914* (Princeton, 1981). More recently, see, for example, Pieter M. Judson, *Guardians of the Nation: Activists on the Language Frontiers of Imperial Austria* (Cambridge, Mass., 2006); Jeremy King, *Budweisers into Czechs and Germans: A Local History of Bohemian Politics, 1848–1948* (Princeton, 2002); Eagle Glassheim, *Noble Nationalists: The Transformation of the Bohemian Aristocracy* (Cambridge, Mass., 2005); Chad Bryant, *Prague in Black: Nazi Rule and Czech Nationalism* (Cambridge, Mass., 2007); James Bjork, *Neither German nor Pole: Catholicism and National Indifference in a Central European Borderland* (Ann Arbor, 2008); Timothy Snyder, *The Reconstruction of Nations: Poland, Ukraine, Lithuania, Belarus, 1569–1999* (New Haven, 2003); Theodora Dragostinova, "Speaking National: Nationalizing the Greeks of Bulgaria," *Slavic Review* 67, no. 1 (Spring 2008): 154–81; Tara Zahra, *Kidnapped Souls: National Indifference and the Battle for Children in the Bohemian Lands, 1900–1948* (Ithaca, 2008).

3. Diane Lewis, "Anthropology and Colonialism," *Current Anthropology* 14, no. 5 (December 1973): 581–602. For an early critique of anthropology's relationship to colonialism, see Talal Asad, ed., *Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter* (London, 1973).

4. This phrase comes from Prasenjit Duara's *Rescuing History from the Nation: Questioning Narratives of Modern China* (Chicago, 1995). On the dominance of the national paradigm in the historical profession, see also Stefan Berger, "A Return to the National Paradigm? National History Writing in Germany, Italy, France, and Britain from 1945 to the Present," *Journal of Modern History* 77, no. 3 (September 2005): 629–78.

Historians of Europe have mostly attempted to dethrone the nation-state by shifting the scale of historical analysis. Comparative history, transfer history, *histoire croisée*, global history, international history, regional history, local history, and, finally, transnational history each have distinctive methods and claims, but all have the potential to challenge the privileged position of the nation-state as the subject and agent of historical change.⁵ In their efforts to explore the limits of nationalization, historians of central and eastern Europe have turned, in particular, to the study of borderlands, localism, and regionalism.⁶ Initially, studies of regionalism and borderlands in modern Europe focused largely on understanding how local and regional identities were rendered compatible with larger nationalizing projects. Alon Confino, for example, analyzed how the concept of *Heimat* in Germany actually helped to consolidate German national unity in the Wilhelmine empire. The notion of *Heimat*, Confino argues, embodied the nation in the locality, enabling citizens to reconcile diverse local and regional loyalties with a larger ideal of German national unity. Likewise, early studies of borderland regions in Europe, most notably Peter Sahlin's *Boundaries*, demonstrated how national communities were consolidated on the periphery of nation-states. These studies illuminated the dynamics of successful nation-building projects rather than exploring the limitations of nationalization.⁷

5. Heinz-Gerhard Haupt and Jürgen Kocka, *Geschichte und Vergleich: Ansätze und Ergebnisse international vergleichender Geschichtsschreibung* (Frankfurt am Main, 1996); Jürgen Kocka, "Comparison and Beyond," *History and Theory* 42, no. 1 (February 2003): 39–44; Heinz-Gerhard Haupt and Jürgen Kocka, "Comparative History: Methods, Aims, Problems," in Deborah Cohen and Maura O'Connor, eds., *Comparison and History: Europe in Cross-National Perspective* (New York, 2004), 23–41. For insightful reflections on the promises and pitfalls of comparative history, see also Nancy L. Green, "Forms of Comparison," Deborah Cohen, "Comparative History: Buyer Beware," and Peter Baldwin, "Comparing and Generalizing: Why All History Is Comparative, Yet No History Is Sociology," all in Cohen and O'Connor, eds., *Comparison and History*, 41–56, 57–70, 1–22.

6. On regionalism and localism, see, among others, Laurence Cole, ed., *Different Paths to the Nation: Regional and National Identities in Central Europe and Italy, 1830–1870* (New York, 2007); Philipp Ther and Holm Sundhaussen, *Regionale Bewegungen und Regionalismus in europäischen Zwischenräumen seit der Mitte des 19. Jahrhunderts* (Marburg, 2003); David Blackbourn and James Retallack, eds., *Localism, Landscape, and the Ambiguities of Place: German-Speaking Central Europe, 1890–1930* (Toronto, 2007); Peter Haslinger and Joachim von Puttkamer, eds., *Staat, Loyalität und Minderheiten in Ostmittel- und Südosteuropa 1918–1941* (Munich, 2007). On borderlands, see Rolf Petri and Michael Müller, *Die Nationalisierung von Grenzen: Zur Konstruktion nationaler Identität in sprachlich gemischten Grenzregionen* (Marburg, 2002); Peter Haslinger, ed., *Grenze im Kopf: Beiträge zur Geschichte der Grenze in Ostmitteleuropa* (New York, 1999); Caitlin Murdock, *Changing Places: Mobilizing Society, Culture, and Territory in Central Europe's Borderlands, 1870–1946* (Ann Arbor, 2010).

7. See, for example, Celia Applegate, "A Europe of Regions: Reflections on the Historiography of Sub-National Places in Modern Times," *American Historical Review* 104, no. 4 (October 1999): 1157–82; Alon Confino, *The Nation as a Local Metaphor: Württemberg, Imperial Germany, and National Memory, 1871–1918* (Chapel Hill, 1997); Stéphane Gerson, *The Pride of Place: Local Memories and Political Culture in Nineteenth-Century France* (Ithaca, 2003); Caroline Ford, *Creating the Nation in Provincial France: Religion and Political Identity in Brittany* (Princeton, 1993); Celia Applegate, *A Nation of Provincials: The German Idea of Heimat* (Berkeley, 1990); Peter Sahlin, *Boundaries: The Making of France and Spain in the Pyrenees* (Berkeley, 1989).

More recently, historians of regionalism, localism, and borderlands in east central Europe have rediscovered populations and individuals who were not so easily swallowed up by the forces of nationalization. The Wasserpolen and Masures in Silesia, the schwenbendes Volkstum of Carinthia, the Lemkos of the Carpathians, the Hultschiners of Moravian Silesia, Transylvania's Szeklers, Bohemia's Budweisers, the tutejzsie in the kresy of the former Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth, Istrians in the Julian March—all seemed on the surface to resist the momentum of modern nation-building projects.⁸ All of these approaches have helped to situate the nation-state in a broader relational and spatial context.

A related strategy has been to scrutinize the history of individual consciousness and subjectivity. Historians have asked to what extent individuals actually felt national, and by extension, to what extent they did *not* feel national. This approach has also rendered national indifference more visible to historians.⁹ The canonical works of nationalism theory, including Benedict Anderson's *Imagined Communities*, Ernest Gellner's *Nations and Nationalism*, Terence Ranger and Eric Hobsbawm's *The Invention of Tradition*, Eric Hobsbawm's *Nations and Nationalism since 1780*, and Eugen Weber's *Peasants into Frenchmen* all focused explicitly on the absence of national loyalties before the modern era. By tracing the painstaking labor of nation building, these scholars definitively dismantled the primordialist claims of nationalists and established a firm consensus among historians that nations are modern, historically and politically constructed communities.¹⁰

Although these scholars posed fatal challenges to primordialist narratives of "national awakening," they did little to question the resonance of nationalist claims and loyalties in the modern era. "Imagined communities" may have become so ubiquitous in historical research that we have inadvertently become blind to individuals who remained altogether aloof to the nation's appeal. Research on the history of nationalism since 1980 has tended, above all, to analyze the contested cultural, political, and social content of nationalist ideologies and discourses, rather than probing the outer limits of nationalizing projects. Even as historians assert that

8. On indifference in the kresy, see Kate Brown, *A Biography of No Place: From Ethnic Borderland to Soviet Heartland* (Cambridge, Mass., 2004); Snyder, *Reconstruction of Nations*. On the Windische, see Andreas Moritsch, "Das Windische—eine nationale Hilfsideologie," in Andreas Moritsch, ed., *Problemfelder der Geschichte und Geschichtsschreibung der Kärntner Slovenen* (Klagenfurt, 1995), 15–29.

9. For a critique of the "ethnicist" presumptions dominating the history of east central Europe, see Jeremy King, "The Nationalization of East Central Europe: Ethnicism, Ethnicity, and Beyond," in Nancy M. Wingfield and Maria Bucur, eds., *Staging the Past: The Politics of Commemoration in Habsburg Central Europe, 1848 to the Present* (West Lafayette, 2001), 112–52.

10. Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London, 1983); Ernest Gellner, *Nations and Nationalism* (Ithaca, 1983); Terence Ranger and Eric Hobsbawm, eds., *The Invention of Tradition* (Cambridge, Eng., 1983); Eric Hobsbawm, *Nations and Nationalism since 1780: Programme, Myth, Reality* (Cambridge, Eng., 1990); Eugen Weber, *Peasants into Frenchmen: The Modernization of Rural France, 1870–1914* (Stanford, 1976).

national groups are imagined communities, they have continued to write the history of eastern Europe in particular with national groups in starring roles, analyzing relations between “the Czechs,” “the Germans,” “the Poles,” “the Slovenes,” as though these collectives were self-evident entities. It may be time, in short, to move beyond imagined communities and to consider the history of individuals who stood outside or on the margins of those communities.

In his essay “Ethnicity without Groups,” Rogers Brubaker challenges social scientists and historians to abandon the assumption that individuals belong to groups and that national groups are coherent social agents. Analyzing “groupness” as an “event” rather than analyzing “nations” as historical actors, he suggests, alerts us to the possibility that groupness “may not happen, that high levels of groupness may fail to crystallize, despite the group-making efforts of ethnopolitical entrepreneurs, and even in situations of intense elite-level ethnic conflict.”¹¹ But what does it mean in practice for historians to make *failed* groupness their subject? Ernest Gellner’s “dogs that failed to bark” pose deep challenges to many of the basic assumptions that have traditionally structured the history of east central Europe.¹² In particular, cultural and social historians of nationalism have largely devoted themselves to demonstrating that nationalists in east central Europe successfully infused every realm of daily life with nationalist significance, breaking down distinctions between putative public and private spheres. Brubaker, however, paints a very different picture of life in postcommunist Cluj. In spite of the highly ethnicized rhetoric that frames political discourse there, he suggests, “most Hungarians, like most Romanians, are largely indifferent to politics, and preoccupied with problems of everyday life—problems that are not interpreted in ethnic terms.”¹³

Here, Brubaker uses the term *politics* as shorthand for high, national politics. He maintains that we cannot simply assume that the nationalization of elite political discourse reflects the intensity of national allegiances or polarization in daily life. But his implicit contrast between the realms of high “politics” and “everyday life” raises a troubling question for social historians. If we discover that nonelites were not nationalized, or that they were indifferent to nationalist appeals, is it because they were not politicized at all? On the surface, this view seems to reinforce the binary opposition between “high politics” and “everyday life” that social and cultural historians, historians of gender in particular, have worked hard to undermine in the past thirty years.

The goal of this article is therefore to historicize national indifference and to explore its potential as a category of analysis, without reinscribing imagined boundaries between the public (political) sphere and the private (apolitical) world of “everyday life” and without evacuating nonelites from politics. Instead, I argue that tensions between nationalist

11. Rogers Brubaker, *Ethnicity without Groups* (Cambridge, Mass., 2004), 12.

12. Gellner, *Nations and Nationalism*, 43.

13. Brubaker, *Ethnicity without Groups*, 22.

aspirations and popular responses to their demands often propelled political change and radicalization in modern east central Europe. In the remainder of this article, I explore three related questions: What is national indifference and does it have a history? What historical and intellectual forces have conspired to obscure national indifference? How does the category of national indifference intersect with or complicate the theoretical agenda of transnational history?

Defining Indifference

Indifference to nationalism is not a new discovery in east European history. It is rather a new label for phenomena that have long attracted the attention of historians and political activists. What we might call indifference has gone by many other names (often derogatory) in the past: regionalism, cosmopolitanism, Catholicism, socialism, localism, bilingualism, intermarriage, opportunism, immorality, backwardness, stubbornness, and false consciousness, to name a few. Nor is national indifference a perfect term, since “indifference” itself carries a pejorative connotation. Alternatives, such as national apathy, ambivalence, lability, or binationalism, hardly seem preferable—indifference can encompass but is not limited to any one of these phenomena. The absence of a suitable term to describe nonnational and nationally ambivalent populations acutely reflects the extent to which nationalist assumptions have shaped the vocabulary of social scientists.

The term *national indifference* can also apply to many different kinds of behavior and people. This is because possibilities for and forms of national indifference have changed radically over time, shifting with the boundaries of states and the political, social, and legal structures in which people lived. National indifference in east central Europe was no more stable or consistent in its form or meaning than nationalism itself in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. Indifference can and should be historicized.

At first glance, it might seem that national indifference was simply a premodern relic—a reflection of local, regional, dynastic, or religious loyalties that were gradually wiped out by the forces of modernization, state building, and modern mass politics. This assumption, of course, lies at the heart of the modernist paradigm established by Anderson, Hobsbawm, Ranger, Gellner, and Weber. In these narratives, nationalization, riding on the tailwinds of modernization, industrialization, and state building, appears to be a one-way ticket to a single destination—the homogenous nation-state. More recent research has suggested, however, that indifference to nationalism actually flourished in the eye of the nationalist storm in Europe between 1880 and 1948. Far from being a premodern relic, national indifference was often a response to modern mass politics.

Weber's seminal *Peasants into Frenchmen* illustrates some of the pitfalls of the modernist paradigm. Weber famously challenged the prevailing assumption that nineteenth-century French peasants and workers were actually French. “From Vosges to Brittany,” French peasants in the nineteenth century were altogether “indifferent to political debate and to is-

sues that did not affect them directly,” he maintains.¹⁴ French workers and peasants were more connected to their local, regional, professional, familial, and religious communities than to any overarching French national community. Perhaps most tellingly, in Europe’s quintessential nation-state, French was a foreign tongue to half the population in 1870.¹⁵ Weber ultimately concludes that “the modern view of the nation as a body of people united according to their own will and having certain attributes in common (not least history) was at best dubiously applicable to the France of 1870.”¹⁶

Peasants into Frenchmen dealt a serious blow to the primordialist claims of nationalist historiography. If France, the quintessential nation-state, was not a unified national state in the nineteenth century, what state could legitimately claim to be a bona fide nation-state? And yet Weber’s narrative is highly teleological, linking modernization and state building inextricably to nationalization. *Peasants into Frenchmen* thus describes the French Third Republic’s relentless campaign to make peasants into Frenchmen by launching an army of civilizing schoolteachers and civil servants into the “backward” countryside, where they suppressed local dialects, traditions, superstitions, and religious practices and imposed a modern, unified “French” culture and bureaucracy. Historians of French regionalism and the French empire have since challenged this top-down account of the relationship between regionalism, colonialism, and nation building in modern France.¹⁷ But *Peasants into Frenchmen*, like many early studies of nations as imagined communities, simultaneously acknowledges national indifference and relegates it to a premodern past.¹⁸ I argue, in contrast, that national indifference persisted well into the twentieth century and that it was produced and reinforced by modern mass politics.

Research on several distinct regions of eastern and southeastern Europe confirms that national ambivalence was not wiped out by the tidal force of modernization. The Upper Silesians studied by Bjork were perhaps the most famously indifferent population in twentieth-century central Europe. In 1906, Father Jan Kapica posed the question, “What is an Upper Silesian? Is he a German, a Pole, a Prussian, simply an Upper Silesian, or simply a Catholic or, perhaps, even just an abstract human being?”¹⁹ His question was never definitively resolved, but this was not because Silesians were marooned in premodernity. Like Bohemia and Alsace-Lorraine, Upper Silesia at the turn of the twentieth century boasted near universal literacy, widespread industrialization, and a vibrant associational culture. Bjork shows that a resilient Catholic subculture in

14. Weber, *Peasants into Frenchmen*, 343.

15. *Ibid.*, 67–94.

16. *Ibid.*, 485.

17. See, for example, Ford, *Creating the Nation*; Gerson, *Pride of Place*; James Daughton, *An Empire Divided: Religion, Republicanism, and the Making of French Colonialism, 1880–1914* (New York, 2006).

18. Weber, *Peasants into Frenchmen*, 494. The conclusion can be read as an apology for French colonialism.

19. Quoted in Bjork, *Neither German nor Pole*, 1.

Upper Silesia, promoted by a nationally indifferent clergy, nonetheless complicated nationalization in the region.

The story of Upper Silesia challenges the teleological assumption that nationalization was irreversible. The persistence of national indifference in Silesia well into the twentieth century forces historians to confront “the possibility that people may be subjected to multiple processes of nationalization without becoming irretrievably immersed in any of them,” Bjork argues.²⁰ After a brief period of nationalist polarization between 1897 and 1907, the *utraquist* Catholic Center Party and the Social Democrats re-emerged as the most powerful political parties in Upper Silesia in the elections of 1912. The nationally ambiguous profiles of these two parties actually facilitated their electoral success, according to Bjork. Ironically, the very stridency of the German and Polish nationalist movements alienated Silesians and helped to augment “the ranks of the nationally-uncertain.” While the German imperial government’s repressive linguistic policies sought to eradicate the Polish language from public life, Polish nationalists construed any use of German as a form of national treason. But neither national camp’s “linguistic absolutism” resonated with Silesians who were accustomed to living in a nationally and linguistically heterogeneous environment. The result was a “growing potential constituency for a supranational politics in what had so recently seemed like a no-man’s-land between nationalist camps.”²¹

In Dalmatia in the mid-nineteenth century, Dominique Reill has found a similar relationship between the rise of modern nationalist movements and a flourishing culture of national ambiguity. Many Dalmatian elites self-consciously asserted that they were both Italian and Slavic, insisting that their special destiny was to mediate between the two cultures.²² In the Julian March, meanwhile, a region of the former Balkans divided between present-day Croatia, Italy, and Slovenia, Pamela Ballinger has shown that Istrians also developed self-consciously “hybrid” identities in response to intense political and social pressure from competing nationalist movements.²³ And in the Bohemian Lands in the early twentieth century, nationalist competition engendered a virtual bidding war for the souls of children. Both Czech and German schools and welfare institutions offered parents free lunches, textbooks, clothing, and even Christmas gifts to attract higher enrollments and expand the ranks of the nation. It is hardly surprising that when questioned about his national loyalties in 1948, one bilingual factory worker frankly replied, “It is a matter of who is giving more.”²⁴

Across eastern Europe, competition between popular nationalist movements on the ground actually encouraged national indifference. But

20. *Ibid.*, 4.

21. *Ibid.*, 172, 129, and 131. On Upper Silesia, see also Kai Struve and Philipp Ther, eds., *Grenzen der Nationen: Identitätenwandel in Oberschlesien in der Neuzeit* (Marburg, 2002).

22. Dominique Reill, “A Mission of Mediation: Dalmatia’s Multi-National Regionalism from the 1830s–60s,” in Cole, ed., *Different Paths to the Nation*, 16–36.

23. Pamela Ballinger, *History in Exile: Memory and Identity at the Borders of the Balkans* (Princeton, 2002), 262.

24. Josef Hůrský, *Zjstování národnosti* (Prague, 1947), 92–94.

the forms of national indifference did change dramatically over time and across regimes. For some, particularly in Habsburg Austria, indifference to nationalism could entail the complete absence of national loyalties—a claim to be neither Czech nor German, neither Polish nor Ruthene, neither German nor Slovene. In the late nineteenth century, however, as Gerald Stourzh and King have shown, the Austrian state itself began to “multinationalize,” acknowledging the so-called rights of national collectives in order to defuse national tensions.²⁵ This made national agnosticism less viable, particularly in regions affected by the so-called national compromises of the early twentieth century (Moravia, Galicia, Bukovina). Once citizens were forced to register their nationality in order to exercise basic civil rights such as the right to vote or to a primary school education, remaining on the national sidelines was no longer simple.

The collapse of the Habsburg empire into self-declared nation-states in 1918 rendered the outright refusal of nationality nearly impossible. The dissolution of the Austrian empire marked the demise of the nationally indifferent or neutral state in east central Europe. The Czechoslovak, Polish, and Yugoslav governments all forcibly classified citizens, hoping to boost the legitimacy of their states domestically and internationally by reducing the number of people counted as members of minority groups.²⁶ Although interwar Czechoslovakia and Yugoslavia were both officially supranational, neither government was nationally indifferent. Czechoslovakia was always conceived of as a nation-state, Elizabeth Bakke has argued. The “Czechoslovak” nation was defined in terms of shared cultural values, the closeness of the Czech and Slovak languages, and racial kinship, and not simply in terms of civic loyalties. Germans, Hungarians, Gypsies, and Poles could not be “Czechoslovaks.”²⁷ There was also very little “Yugoslavism” in interwar Yugoslavia, either at the level of political parties, the educational system, or cultural and religious organizations.²⁸ Yugoslavism shared the exclusionary logic of the nation-state, Charles Jelavich has argued, since “the non-Slavs, the Albanians, Germans, Greeks, Hungarians, Romanians, Turks, and others, were not a part of the equation.”²⁹

The Soviet Union is of course the classic example of how an officially supranational state actually contributed to the eradication of national in-

25. King, *Budweisers*, 114–53; Gerald Stourzh, *Die Gleichberechtigung der Nationalitäten in der Verfassung und Verwaltung Österreichs* (Vienna, 1985).

26. On national classification, see Tara Zahra, “The ‘Minority Problem’ and National Classification in the French and Czechoslovak Borderlands,” *Contemporary European History* 17, no. 2 (May 2008): 137–65.

27. Elizabeth Bakke, “The Making of Czechoslovakism in the First Czechoslovak Republic,” in Martin Schulze-Wessel, ed., *Loyalitäten in der Tschechoslowakischen Republik, 1918–1938* (Munich, 2004), 23–44.

28. Srećko M. Džaja, *Die politische Realität des Jugoslawismus (1918–1991)* (Munich, 2002); See also Charles Jelavich, “South Slav Education: Was There Yugoslavism?” and Arnold Suppan, “Yugoslavism versus Serbian, Croatian, and Slovene Nationalism: Political, Ideological, and Cultural Causes of the Rise and Fall of Yugoslavia,” both in Norman M. Naimark and Holly Case, eds., *Yugoslavia and Its Historians: Understanding the Balkan Wars* (Stanford, 2003), 93–115 and 116–39.

29. Jelavich, “South Slav Education,” 95.

difference. Recent research by Terry Martin, Francine Hirsch, Yuri Slezkine, and others has stressed the central role of the Soviet government in nationalizing the Soviet population. Soviet policymakers strategically consolidated national communities in the early twentieth century, often cutting them from whole cloth through national classification and nationalizing linguistic, cultural, and education policies. In the long-run, Soviet officials hoped to placate political nationalism by encouraging cultural nationalism.³⁰

Building on these arguments, Brown's *Biography of No Place* traces the fraught encounters between Soviet officials and rural populations in the kresy, the borderland regions between historic Poland and Russia. In these regions, Soviet officials quickly discovered that indifference to nationalism was more the norm than the exception. In 1925, for example, Jan Saulevich, Secretary for the Ukrainian Commission for National Minority Affairs, was charged with the task of taking a national inventory of the kresy, in order to implement Soviet plans for the establishment of a Ukrainian autonomous region. He reported with dismay that "Ukrainians and Poles hardly differ from one another in their material existence beyond their conversational language—however, language too is problematic because the local Polish sounds very much like the local Ukrainian." To complicate matters, much of the population was bilingual.³¹ Confounded, officials attempted to ask people about their national loyalties, but this was hardly helpful. Local Polish- and Ukrainian-speakers alike often insisted that they were simply peasants. Others replied that they belonged to the "Catholic" nationality. Some identified themselves as tutejzsie, or "people from here." One peasant claimed that he spoke "the Catholic language," while others simply insisted that they spoke "in the peasant way" or in "the language of here."³²

Of course, forcible classification went a long way toward eradicating this kind of national ambiguity. Increasingly, after 1918 in eastern Europe, nationality became an explicit basis for citizenship rights and for securing voting privileges, education, and social services in the Habsburg successor states and in the Soviet Union. Nationalist activists themselves gleefully celebrated the demise of national indifference in the aftermath of the revolution of 1918. Hugo Heller, a German child welfare activist in Bohemia, boasted that, after the revolution, nationalist enthusiasm "rushed in like a fresh spring, awakening life throughout all of German Bohemia, melting the snow and ice of national ambivalence, dispersing the clouds which had paralyzed and depressed nationalist thought, feeling, and will. . . . Those were the good times!"³³

30. Terry Martin, *The Affirmative Action Empire: Nations and Nationalism in the Soviet Union, 1923–1939* (Ithaca, 2001); Francine Hirsch, *Empire of Nations: Ethnographic Knowledge and the Making of the Soviet Union* (Ithaca, 2005); Yuri Slezkine, "The USSR as a Communal Apartment, or How a Socialist State Promoted Ethnic Particularism," *Slavic Review* 53, no. 2 (Summer 1994): 414–52.

31. Brown, *Biography of No Place*, 33.

32. *Ibid.*, 39.

33. Hugo Heller, *Die Erziehung zum deutschen Wesen* (Prague, 1936), 9.

Sadly for Heller and his nationalist friends, however, the good times did not last. The collapse of eastern Europe's continental empires in 1918 did not spell the end of national indifference but rather encouraged its expression in different forms. In the Bohemian Lands, for example, many Czech-speakers continued to marry German-speakers and vice-versa, and in such families, bilingualism and fluid national loyalties were the norm. Other citizens also remained on the fence when it came to national affiliation. These individuals switched sides depending on political and social circumstances. The number of German-speakers in Czechoslovakia declined by 400,000 from 1910 to 1921, for example. In some towns such as Budějovice/Budweis, the number of people registering as Germans dropped by as much as 50 percent.³⁴

Where did all the Germans go? Some died in the war, some emigrated to Austria or Germany, some gave in to state pressure to become "Czechoslovaks," and some registered as members of the newly created Jewish nationality. Many others, however, were simply side-switchers, who saw that membership in the nation-state could have its privileges. Even more individuals may have considered themselves nominally Czechs, Germans, Poles, or Hungarians, although they rejected the strident demands of nationalist politicians. Nationalist organizers in the early twentieth-century worked tirelessly to educate citizens about the many duties that accompanied national belonging. Being a good German did not simply entail casting a ballot for nationalist politicians on election day. Loyal Germans were to shop exclusively in German-owned stores, visit endangered German "language frontiers" on vacation, join German choral groups, fire companies, and associations (and regularly make financial contributions), speak only German at home, marry Germans, hire German nannies, and send their children exclusively to German kindergartens, summer camps, and schools.³⁵ Not surprisingly, relatively few individuals managed to keep up with the exhausting demands of the nationalist lifestyle. By 1930 in Czechoslovakia, so-called activist parties, such as the Social Democrats, the Agrarian Party, and the Christian Social Party, enjoyed the support of a full 75 percent of the German population. These parties were primarily organized around non-nationalist concerns and issues. Only in the mid-1930s, when the Great Depression began to inflict the worst on German-speaking industrial regions, did German-speakers increasingly turn toward the nationalist Sudeten German Party.³⁶

Nor was indifference easily banished from interwar Poland and Hungary. Thousands of German-speaking Protestants in central and eastern Poland declared themselves Poles on interwar Poland's first census in 1921. In Łódź, Poland's second largest city, such individuals were known as "Łodzermenschen." Josef Spickermann, a delegate to the Sejm from

34. King, *Budweisers*, 164–66.

35. See, for example, Judson, *Guardians of the Nation*; Nancy M. Wingfield, *Flag Wars and Stone Saints: How the Bohemian Lands Became Czech* (Cambridge, Mass., 2007); Elizabeth Harvey, *Women and the Nazi East: Agents and Witnesses of Germanization* (New Haven, 2003); Bryant, *Prague in Black*; Zahra, *Kidnapped Souls*.

36. Zahra, *Kidnapped Souls*, 144.

Łódź, vehemently rejected pan-Germanism in a speech in March 1919, declaring, “We, the citizens of German ethnicity, consider Poland our Fatherland. . . . Our entire psyche is completely different from that of the Germans on the other side of the border. . . . We are ready to give our property and our lives in order to do everything we can to create a strong and powerful Poland.”³⁷ In Hungary in 1941, meanwhile, 174,995 individuals declared German as their native tongue on the Hungarian census but simultaneously registered as members of the Hungarian nationality. A report by a local census official indicated that most German-speaking Hungarians cared more about protecting their land and property than about preserving a German national identity, explaining, “The Swabian population feels at home here, wants to stay here, is attached to the land. They are willing to disavow not only their nationality but also their mother tongue if that small price would allow them to remain here.”³⁸ In the Burgenland region of Austria, meanwhile, the Nazi party successfully recruited Hungarian- and Croatian-speakers in the late 1930s, and even organized local party rallies and events in Hungarian and Croatian.³⁹

Nationalist politicians across east central Europe decried such individuals as opportunists, collaborators, and traitors. In interwar Czechoslovakia, for example, teachers alleged that German-speaking parents who sent their children to Czech schools “seriously damage their nation and thereby work for its extinction. This is the result of . . . national indifference that should be a punishable offense.”⁴⁰ But such individuals were not necessarily victims of false consciousness, political and economic pressure, or moral lassitude—they simply did not organize their lives or political allegiances according to nationalist priorities.

Given the diversity of behaviors and attitudes that can be grouped under the rubric of “national indifference,” it is worth asking if the term is too broad to be useful. The coherence of the category, I believe, ultimately lies in nationalists’ own use of it to mobilize potential recruits. Regardless of diverse motivations and interests, nationally indifferent individuals were denounced, boycotted, and rallied for the national cause as though they belonged to a common species. To nationalists in Habsburg Austria and its successor states, these frustrating individuals were known as “hermaphrodites,” “amphibians,” “renegades,” “utraquists,” and “borderland souls.” The Nazi regime anointed them the “in-between Strata” and “me-too Germans.” And after World War II they were finally denounced

37. Quoted in Ingo Eser, “‘Loyalität’ als Mittel der Integration oder Restriktion? Polen und seine deutsche Minderheit, 1918–1939,” in Haslinger and von Puttkamer, eds., *Staat, Loyalität und Minderheiten*, 23–24.

38. Gerhard Seewann, “‘Ungarndeutschtum’ als Identitätskonzept und politische Ressource,” in Haslinger and von Puttkamer, eds., *Staat, Loyalität und Minderheiten*, 20, 99–126.

39. Gerhard Baumgartner and Ursula Hemetek, *6 x Österreich: Geschichte und aktuelle Situation der Volksgruppen* (Klagenfurt, 1995), 60.

40. Anonymous, *Unsere deutsche Schulen und das Vernichtungsgesetz* (Eger, 1920), 7.

and sometimes expelled as “nationally labile opportunists” or simply as traitors.

National indifference is therefore fundamentally a negative and nationalist category. Indifference only existed as such in the eyes of the nationalist beholder. Ironically, however, this imagined noncommunity was brought to life and institutionalized through nationalists’ own persistent efforts to eradicate it. As historians, this means we need to proceed with caution lest we fall into the trap of using nationalist categories of practice as categories of analysis.⁴¹ This does not mean shunning the category of national indifference altogether, however, any more than we avoid the terms *nation* or *nationalism*. Once imagined, indifference to nationalism became as real and meaningful a category as the nation itself and had significant social, cultural, and political consequences.

National indifference came to be perceived as a social and political phenomenon through nationalist activism, but national, imperial, and even international authorities increasingly acknowledged its existence and institutionalized it. After 1918, for example, guarantees of minority rights in international treaties and in eastern European constitutions raised bitter disputes about who belonged to these “minorities” and who would thus be entitled to claim minority rights. National indifference became the focus of international diplomatic disputes as well as blistering domestic conflicts. A 1922 agreement between Poland and Germany regarding Upper Silesia, for example, specified that German children in that province were to enjoy the “minority right” to attend German-language elementary schools. But which children were German and which were Polish? Disputes over the language abilities and national affiliations of individual children ultimately reached the new League of Nations World Court.⁴² The World Court officially recognized national indifference, conceding that neither nationality nor language abilities were transparent in Silesia: “There is reason to believe that in the conditions which exist in Upper Silesia . . . the question of whether a person belongs to a minority . . . does not clearly appear from the facts. Such an uncertainty might for example exist, as regards language, where either a person does not speak literary German or literary Polish, or where he knows and makes use of several languages, and as regards race, in the case of mixed marriages.”⁴³ This is just one example of how national indifference gradually became

41. On the danger of conflating categories of analysis with categories of practice, see Brubaker, *Ethnicity without Groups*; Rogers Brubaker, Margit Feischmidt, Jon Fox, and Li-ana Grancea, *Nationalist Politics and Everyday Ethnicity in a Transylvanian Town* (Princeton, 2006).

42. For the details of the case, see Manley O. Hudson, ed., *World Court Reports: A Collection of the Judgments, Orders and Opinions of the Permanent Court of International Justice*, vol. 2, 1927–1932 (Washington, D.C., 1935), 268–320, 690–91.

43. Hudson, ed., *World Court Reports*, 292. For more on the issue of Silesian schools, see Carole Fink, *Defending the Rights of Others: The Great Powers, the Jews, and International Minority Protection, 1878–1938* (New York, 2004); Christian Raitz von Frentz, *A Lesson Forgotten: Minority Protection under the League of Nations: The Case of the German Minority in Poland, 1920–1934* (New York, 1999).

far more than a thorn in the side of nationalist agitators. In an age of nationalizing states and international minority-rights protections, indifference to nation was at the heart of both domestic and diplomatic conflicts, new forms of international law, and new ideals of minority rights.

Finding Indifference

Paradoxically, nationalists both invented national indifference and, until recently, deliberately obscured it. In the east European context, national indifference has long been effaced from the historical record by the nationalist frameworks, narratives, and categories that dominate historical analysis and the sources historians rely on: censuses that denied the existence of bilingualism, color-coded ethnographic maps, sensationalist newspaper accounts that transformed drunken bar brawls and children's games into fierce battles for national survival.⁴⁴ There are also practical challenges to studying an imagined noncommunity. Indifferent people are rarely well organized. Unlike nationalism, national indifference has not left much of a paper trail, since most state archives are devoted precisely to documenting the history of nation-states. National indifference was not memorialized with public monuments or celebrated with festivals, costumes, and songs. There was no Association for the Protection of National Hermaphrodites nor was there a Nonnational Peoples' Party. Attempts to create such parties, such as the Moravian *Mittelpartei* of great landowners at the turn of the century, ultimately failed.⁴⁵ Austrian imperial institutions that explicitly claimed to transcend divisions of nationality or language, such as the Social Democratic Party, the nobility, the Catholic Church, the army, and the civil service, represented diverse constituencies that were unlikely to unite in defense of national indifference. In the twentieth century, many of these supranational institutions were themselves increasingly nationalized. It is no coincidence, therefore, that national indifference appears most clearly in the archives at the moment that nationalists mobilized to extinguish it.

It is therefore challenging to quantify indifference, much as we might like to know whether the indifferent constituted a significant mass or an exotic fringe group. The very systems devised for counting and classifying populations in the nineteenth century were shaped by nationalist goals, with an eye to eliminating or obscuring indifference. Occasionally, there have been official efforts to track and quantify national indifference in east central Europe, but these typically met determined resistance. In an unusual concession to the nationally indifferent population in 1930, for example, the Czechoslovak State Statistical Office proposed that citizens be permitted to declare themselves "without nationality" (*bez národnosti*) or "of unknown nationality" (*národnost neznáma*) on the decennial census,

44. See Judson, *Guardians of the Nation*, esp. 1–18.

45. On the *Mittelpartei* in Moravia, see Robert R. Luft, "Die *Mittelpartei* des mährischen Grossgrundbesitzes 1879–1918," in Ferdinand Seibt, ed., *Die Chance der Verständigung: Absichten und Ansätze zu übernationaler Zusammenarbeit in den böhmischen Ländern 1848–1918* (Munich, 1987), 218–36.

just as it was possible to register one's lack of religious affiliation. "Not all people have national feelings or consciousness, or the desire to belong to a specific national community," officials in the Statistical Office conceded. But Czech nationalists harshly rejected this view. Activists in the Czech National Council, an umbrella organization for Czech voluntary associations and political parties, warned that allowing citizens to opt out of the nation on the census would "make it impossible to obtain a clear overview of the national composition of the state, wearing away at its borders."⁴⁶ Their viewpoint prevailed, and the indifferent were denied the chance to be counted.

It is possible, however, to use certain statistical measures to (imperfectly) estimate the number of nationally ambivalent people in a given time or place. In the Bohemian Lands, for example, one demographer found that in Prague in 1900, 16.6 percent of schoolchildren were bilingual. In Budějovice/Budweis, the percentage of bilingual children reached 16.2 percent, in Liberec/Reichenberg, 16.1 percent, and in Most/Brüx, 22.4 percent.⁴⁷ These statistics must be treated with caution, as the political pressure to underreport bilingualism was considerable. Bilingualism, moreover, has no intrinsic relationship to national indifference. Many of the early Czech nationalist "awakeners" were famously bilingual, for example.⁴⁸ But by the late nineteenth century in Habsburg central Europe, many nationalist education experts began to see bilingualism as evidence of national indifference. Shortly after the 1880 Austrian census, Jan Kapras, a Czech gymnasium teacher in Brno/Brünn, excoriated Moravian parents who raised their children in bilingual households, proclaiming, "This is the class of linguistically neutral hermaphrodites, who sail to any wind, calling themselves Czech here, German there, and are educated to constantly go back on their word."⁴⁹

Fluctuations in census numbers offer another potential measure of national lability: the loss of 400,000 German-speakers in the Bohemian Lands between 1910 and 1921 suggests that side-switchers were not isolated eccentrics. In 1946, Ministry of Interior officials in Czechoslovakia estimated that at least 300,000 Czechs had "become German" during the Nazi occupation of the Bohemian Lands.⁵⁰ This so-called *Zwischenschicht* of nationally ambivalent people obsessed Nazi officials in occupied eastern Europe. In 1940, many German-speakers in the Protectorate were reluctant to register as Germans, whether out of ideological opposition to the Nazis or (more often) fear of being drafted into the Wehrmacht. "Through

46. Sčítání lidu 1930, Memo from the Czech National Council to the State Statistical Office and the Presidium of the Council of Ministers, 16 May 1930, Carton 183, Národní rada česká, Národní archiv (NA), Prague.

47. Heinrich Rauchberg, *Der nationale Besitzstand in Böhmen* (Leipzig, 1905), 435.

48. On early Czech nationalists, see Peter Bugge, "Czech Nation-Building, National Self-Perception and Politics, 1780–1914" (PhD diss., University of Aarhus, 1994).

49. Jan Kapras, *Řeč mateská orgánem školy obecné a znakem národnosti* (Prague, 1883), 9–10.

50. Benjamin Frommer, *National Cleansing: Retribution against Nazi Collaborators in Postwar Czechoslovakia* (Cambridge, Eng., 2005), 18.

the proven work of National Socialist education there is no doubt that the offspring of today's indecisive, madly behaving Volksdeutsche will become the most valuable members of the German citizenry," Protectorate officials reassured themselves.⁵¹

Thus even if the nationally indifferent were actually a small minority by the early twentieth century, national indifference was historically significant. In nationalist rhetoric, national indifference loomed larger than life and therefore played an extraordinary role in shaping nationalist activism and political and social institutions in modern east central Europe. From the mid-nineteenth century until after World War II, nationalists obsessed over the problem of national indifference and devised new strategies to eradicate it. They tried bribery and persuasion, seeking to awaken the loyalties of nationally indifferent citizens with generous offers of welfare benefits and calls to conscience. But when gentler methods failed, nationalist activists and state officials resorted to more disciplinary tactics, including forcible national classification in interwar eastern Europe and in Nazi-occupied east central Europe.

Indifference was important to the development of modern nationalism, not only because nationalists reacted so strongly to it, but because it compelled nationalist movements to define the boundaries of the national community more precisely. Was the nation a voluntary community of all those who believed themselves to be Czechs, Slovenes, Poles, French, or Germans, or of those who learned to speak a language or adopted certain cultural practices? Or was the nation defined by descent or "blood" alone? Was national belonging an expression of political commitments (for example, to Nazism or to democracy?) Or of cultural and economic status? The answers to these questions were never stable, but they often developed precisely through confrontations between nationalists and indifferent populations. For example, Czech nationalists, officials, and legal experts increasingly demanded policies of forced inclusion or national ascription in order to prevent indifferent or opportunist "Czechs" from joining the German camp. In the early twentieth century, they shifted away from language and toward descent as the defining mark of Czech nationality in order to reign in potential national "renegades."⁵²

National indifference, and attempts to eradicate it, were not confined to eastern Europe. In Alsace-Lorraine after World War I, French officials also adopted practices of forcible national classification as they sought to distinguish between German subjects and French citizens and to punish the vanquished Germans. Beginning in February of 1919, French officials began to classify the entire population of Alsace into four categories, issuing identity cards that entitled the holders to different forms of treatment. The *Carte A* was reserved for Alsatians who were born in Alsace and whose parents or grandparents carried French citizenship before 1870. Individuals of so-called mixed heritage, those with one parent who had carried

51. Generalreferat für politische Angelegenheiten, Prague, 12 August 1939. Carton 520, Úřad říšského protektora, NA.

52. Zahra, *Kidnapped Souls*, 193.

French citizenship, were assigned the *Carte B*. The *Carte C* was issued to foreigners from allied states. Finally, the *Carte D* was conferred on individuals who were born in Germany or Austria or whose parents or grandparents were born in Germany or Austria.⁵³ French officials introduced these identity cards explicitly to stamp out what they saw as the menace of national ambiguity. The Francophile Alsatian exile and former senator Émile Wetterlé explained in 1915, "Too often the Austro-Germans, who don't shy away from any disloyal maneuver in order to assure their own impunity, have attempted to pass for locals . . . those of us who have a great deal of practical experience with the two populations of our provinces, we can recognize the true German and the true Alsatian or Lorrainer of old stock at first glance. . . . We sniff out the Teuton like a hunting dog sniffs its prey, and I assure you that with a little practice it is not difficult, because the odor is so particular and so strong."⁵⁴

Under Nazi occupation, German officials insisted that the German nation was defined by race or blood, at least rhetorically. In practice, however, Nazi officials also took liberal advantage of national indifference in eastern Europe, keeping the doors of the *Volksgemeinschaft* open to many non-Jews who professed to Nazi ideals. George Kennan, the American diplomat, observed that shortly after the Nazi occupation of the Bohemian Lands, "It became difficult to tell where the Czech left off and the German began."⁵⁵ Doris Bergen has found that national indifference in Nazi-occupied Poland contributed to the escalation of antisemitic violence. As nationally ambiguous individuals attempted to improve their ranking on the four-tiered German *Volksliste*, some resorted to antisemitic language and violence in order to "prove" their questionable loyalties to Germandom.⁵⁶ In each of these cases, the "indifferent" may have been a numerical minority of the population. But in each case, the existence of this minority exposed the limits and contradictions of nationalist ideologies and drove state officials to devise more radical strategies for policing the boundaries of the nation.

Broader historiographical and theoretical trends well outside the field of east central European history have also conspired to efface national indifference. For the last twenty years, many social and cultural historians have focused precisely on the historical construction of identities, especially race, gender, sexuality, and nation. The concept of national indif-

53. On Alsace, see Christopher J. Fischer, "Alsace to the Alsatians? Visions and Divisions of Alsatian Regionalism, 1890–1930" (PhD diss., University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill, 2003); Laird Boswell, "From Liberation to Purge Trials in the 'Mythic Provinces': Recasting French Identities in Alsace and Lorraine, 1918–1920," *French Historical Studies* 23, no. 1 (Winter 2000): 129–62; Zahra, "The 'Minority Problem.'"

54. L'abbé Émile Wetterlé, *Ce qu'était l'Alsace-Lorraine et ce qu'elle sera* (Paris, 1915), 305.

55. Cited in King, *Budweisers*, 176. From George Kennan, *From Prague after Munich, Diplomatic Papers 1938–1940* (Princeton, 1968), 134.

56. See Doris Bergen, "The Nazi Concept of 'Volksdeutsche' and the Exacerbation of Anti-Semitism in Eastern Europe, 1939–45," *Journal of Contemporary History* 29, no. 4 (October 1994): 569–82; on Germanization in Nazi-occupied Europe, see also Mark Mazower, *Hitler's Empire: How the Nazis Ruled Europe* (New York, 2008).

ference rests solidly on this constructivist scholarship, which first insisted that national belonging is a state of mind rather than a biological fact. But a basic assumption behind much constructivist scholarship has been that identities matter, that everyone has (and had) them, that they profoundly shape individual experience, political culture, and historical change.⁵⁷ While historians have amply documented the ways in which gender, racial, class, and national categories have overlapped, transformed, been contested, or destabilized over time, they have paid less attention to individuals who remained aloof to the demands of modern identity politics. "Identity" itself matters so much in our current political and cultural landscape that it is challenging to imagine a time when it might not have mattered so much, or in the same ways.

In a provocative essay entitled "Beyond Identity," Rogers Brubaker and Frederick Cooper argue that we should eschew the term *identity* altogether. Identity, they maintain, is too torn between its "hard" and "soft" meanings to be useful. In its "hard" form, identity essentializes people by assuming that they belong to rigidly defined groups. In its "soft" form, diluted by a string of qualifications (that identity is "multiple," "fluid," "contested," and "constructed") identity is so ambiguous that it is meaningless. "If identity is everywhere, it is nowhere," they suggest.⁵⁸ Many scholars have recently begun to substitute less reductionist terms, such as "loyalty," "affiliation," "identification," "self-understanding," and "subject position." Peter Haslinger, Joachim von Puttkamer, and Martin Schulze-Wessel contend, for example, that the concept of "loyalty" enables scholars to explore the history of collective forms of consciousness without the essentializing baggage of identity politics.⁵⁹ While "identity" conveys an "illusion of stability," and appears to be "constitutional," the concept of loyalty, they argue, better underscores the agency of the individual.⁶⁰

Loyalty is certainly a productive category for historical research. It does not, however, necessarily banish the basic assumption that everyone in east central Europe had a national affiliation in the twentieth century—even if we are more aware, as Robert Musil famously observed, that individuals might boast "a professional, a civic, a class, a geographic, a sexual, a conscious, an unconscious, and possibly even a private character to boot."⁶¹ Research on "loyalty" in eastern Europe tends to analyze the reasons why individual civic, imperial, local, religious, or regional loyalties diverged from, reinforced, overlapped with, or competed with national loyalties. But this research rarely questions the existence of national loyalties or of

57. Brubaker, *Ethnicity without Groups*, 3.

58. Rogers Brubaker and Fred Cooper, "Beyond 'Identity,'" *Theory and Society* 29, no. 1 (February 2000): 1.

59. Martin Schulze-Wessel, "Loyalität als Geschichtlicher Grundbegriff und Forschungskonzept: Zur Einleitung," in Schulze-Wessel, ed., *Loyalitäten in der Tschechoslowakischen Republik*, 10.

60. Peter Haslinger and Joachim von Puttkamer, "Staatsmacht, Minderheit, Loyalitätskonzeptionelle Grundlagen am Beispiel Ostmittel und Südosteuropas in der Zwischenkriegszeit," in Haslinger and von Puttkamer, eds., *Staat, Loyalität und Minderheiten*, 2–3, 9.

61. Robert Musil, *The Man without Qualities*, trans. Sophie Wilkins (New York, 1995), 30.

“national minorities” as self-evident communities.⁶² As with identity, it is ultimately too easy to substitute one reductionist view of loyalty for another. In exploring national indifference, we should not seek to replace the nation with something else, assuming that other modes of collective identification were more authentic, real, compelling, or genuine than nationality. So-called national hermaphrodites were not *really* Catholics, regionalists, localists, Jews, Austrian patriots, cosmopolitans, or socialists. Nor should we be searching for an underlying hierarchy of loyalties, ranking religion, class, race, gender, or region against or above nation.

In addition to a post-1968 focus on identity and identity politics in the United States, indifference to nationalism has been effaced in part by the cultural and linguistic turns that have so energized the study of nation, gender, and race as categories of analysis. In the 1960s and 1970s, the working class often played the starring role in social histories that sought to understand the relationship between class experience and political agency. Thatcherism and the fall of communism largely displaced the working class from its heroic role as the agent of history in the late 1980s, and many historians borrowed new methodologies from literary studies. They shifted their focus from class and social experience to the broader realms of culture and politics. In some of the theory war’s most divisive moments, practitioners of the new cultural history were accused of evacuating politics from history altogether. In fact, the appeal of cultural studies to many social historians was precisely that it located politics and power everywhere, and not just in the words and actions of elites. The blossoming fields of gender and sexuality history, postcolonial history, and nationalism studies since the early 1990s are perhaps the most important products of this insight. It is not always easy to find women in the history of elite politics, for example; but, as Joan Scott famously noted, gender structures the political and social order itself. Gender is everywhere, even where women are scarce.⁶³

The nation, like gender and race, became ubiquitous thanks in part to historians’ greater focus on textual and cultural sources. It was never a challenge to find nationalism in the halls of parliament or provincial diets of the late Austrian empire and its successor states, but in the past twenty years historians have located nationalism in every nook and cranny of daily life. Scholars have sniffed it out in literature, maps, exhibitions, architecture, advertisements, films, postcards, schoolbooks, home décor, and travel guides. The problem is that historians who analyze nations as

62. With few exceptions, the essays in Haslinger and von Puttkamer’s volume on state, loyalty, and minorities in east central and southeastern Europe do not question the extent to which “national minorities” existed as self-evident communities. Two exceptions are Albert F. Reiterer, “Abkehr, Widerstand, Loyalität: Die Minderheiten und die Erste Österreichische Republik,” and Elena Mannová, “Identitätsdiskurse und lokale Lebenswelten in der Südslowakei,” both in Haslinger and von Puttkamer, eds., *Staat, Loyalität und Minderheiten*, 141 and 45–67.

63. Joan W. Scott, “Gender: A Useful Category of Historical Analysis,” *American Historical Review* 91, no. 5 (December 1986): 1053–75. On the trajectory from social to cultural history, see Geoff Eley, *A Crooked Line: From Cultural History to the History of Society* (Ann Arbor, 2005).

“imagined communities” risk remaining imprisoned within nationalists’ own discursive universe, analyzing the contested content of nationalist ideologies and cultures without questioning the extent to which those ideologies resonated among their audiences.

Nationalism’s apparent ubiquity in the realms of modern culture and discourse has the dangerous potential to reinforce a totalitarian framework for understanding east central European politics and society. Historians have often linked the rise of nationalist and mass political movements in the late nineteenth century to the so-called destruction or invasion of the private sphere, a beginning step on the slippery slope toward totalitarianism. But narratives linking mass politics to the destruction of the private sphere tend to overestimate the institutional power and resonance of nationalist rhetoric. Until 1918 in Habsburg central Europe, nationalists typically did not have state power at their disposal, except at the local or provincial levels. Their ability to impose their worldview on others was severely restricted. Even very powerful states are limited in their ability to mold populations at will, as revisionist scholarship on both Nazism and communism has suggested over the past several decades. This literature has persuasively highlighted the extent to which so-called totalitarian states sought to negotiate the consent of the governed, the role of denunciation and popular participation in policing, and the agency of citizens within their supposedly totalitarian societies. Surprisingly, however, scholars have been slower to apply insights about the limits of state power to the history of nationalism and nationalizing states.⁶⁴

From a contemporary perspective it is difficult to give up a view of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries as an exceptionally politicized and nationalized moment in the European past. Standard accounts hold that the early twentieth century was the age of ideology: of mass politics, utopian state planning, and the rise of interventionist welfare states, all justified in the name of improving the nation’s collective health and welfare. Many historians have argued that after 1945, by contrast, politics itself was displaced by the market in the west, and the individualist ethics of capitalism, consumerism, domesticity, and human rights triumphed over collectivist ideals. Self-realization took place in the shopping mall and kitchen rather than in the union hall, nationalist association, or on the streets.⁶⁵ But perhaps it is worth considering whether this narrative

64. For a recent reflection on revisionism in Soviet historiography, see Sheila Fitzpatrick, ed., *Stalinism: New Directions* (London, 2000); Sheila Fitzpatrick, “Revisionism in Soviet History,” *History and Theory* 46, no. 4 (December 2007): 77–91; Sheila Fitzpatrick and Michael Geyer, “Introduction: After Totalitarianism. Stalinism and Nazism Compared,” in Michael Geyer and Sheila Fitzpatrick, eds., *Beyond Totalitarianism: Stalinism and Nazism Compared* (Cambridge, Eng., 2009), 1–40. Some examples of this approach in the historiography of Nazi Germany include Robert Gellately, *Backing Hitler: Consent and Coercion in Nazi Germany* (Oxford, 2001); Detlev Peukert, *Inside Nazi Germany: Conformity, Opposition, and Racism in Everyday Life* (New Haven, 1987).

65. On the presumed triumph of individualism in postwar west European politics and human rights activism, see Tony Judt, *Postwar: A History of Europe since 1945* (New York, 2005), 564–65; Paul Lauren, *The Evolution of International Human Rights* (Philadelphia, 1998); Mark Mazower, “The Strange Triumph of Human Rights, 1933–1950,” *The Histori-*

overestimates the political consciousness and commitments of ordinary people in an earlier era, as well as the absence of ideology after World War II.⁶⁶

Historians tend to focus on politics and political commitments, even to assume them, because the one thing uniting us methodologically is an interest in change. We operate on the assumption that change is a product of political commitment and agency, particularly since it is no longer typically seen as a product of dialectic class conflict or anonymous forces of “modernization.” The study of indifference hardly seems to get us anywhere—where is the agency in apathy? But the solution is not to resurrect imagined divides between public and private. Nor should we draw the conclusion that nonelites were indifferent to nationalism because they were altogether indifferent to politics. Rather, it seems more productive to analyze inaction, evasion, and indifference as potential forms of political agency.⁶⁷

Research on daily life under Nazism and communism offers useful comparative insights on the potential political valence of national indifference. What should we make, for example, of the oft-cited appearance of “normality” in daily life during World War II in Germany? Few historians would argue that Germans living “normal” lives in 1942 were not implicated in a political system or relevant to its functioning.⁶⁸ Under what circumstances was seeming indifference to politics a form of accommodation to (and even support for) a political regime, and under what circumstances was indifference an act of active or passive resistance?⁶⁹ A conscious retreat into private life or an outward rejection of politics might be interpreted as a political statement under any regime that demands unwavering commitment. Indifference, like silence, is nonetheless challenging to interpret and can only be understood situationally. It does not belong to the Left or the Right, to women or men, to cowardly collaborators or a heroic resistance. It was not monopolized by religiously devout and “backward” peasants, materialistic workers, or Jewish “cosmopolitans,” though such stereotypes and prejudices flourished in the national-

cal Journal 47, no. 2 (Spring 2004): 386–88; A. W. Brian Simpson, *Human Rights and the End of Empire: Britain and the Genesis of the European Convention* (Oxford, 2001), 157–220; Elizabeth Borgwardt, *A New Deal for the World: America's Vision for Human Rights* (Cambridge, Mass., 2005), 59.

66. For an argument contesting the apolitical nature of postwar Europe, see Mary Nolan, “Utopian Visions in a Post Utopian Era: Human Rights, Americanism, Market Fundamentalism” (keynote address for conference on “Utopia, Gender, and Human Rights,” Vienna, 12 December 2007).

67. For reflections on the agency exercised by peasants through evasion or inaction, see James C. Scott, *Weapons of the Weak: Everyday Forms of Peasant Resistance* (New Haven, 1985).

68. On “normality” and Nazism, see Ian Kershaw, “‘Normality’ and Genocide: The Problem of Historicization,” *The Nazi Dictatorship: Problems and Perspectives of Interpretation* (London, 1993); Peukert, *Inside Nazi Germany*; Harvey, *Women in the Nazi East*; Alf Lüdtke, *The History of Everyday Life* (Princeton, 1995).

69. See Klaus Michel Mallman and Gerhard Paul, “Omniscient, Omnipotent, Omnipresent? Gestapo, Society, and Resistance,” in David F. Crew, ed., *Nazism and German Society, 1933–1945* (New York, 1994); Gellately, *Backing Hitler*.

ist press. It was not a mark of innocence. During and after World War II in Germany, indifference may have signaled a desire for “normality” and privacy in the aftermath of Total War, ambivalence about Nazi policies, or a conscious or unconscious decision to turn a blind eye to the persecution of others while benefiting from racial plunder.⁷⁰ The example of Nazi Germany is extreme, but in twentieth-century Europe, indifference to politics has rarely been entirely apolitical and has instead carried multiple possible political meanings.

This means resisting the temptation to either romanticize or pathologize nationally indifferent populations. It would be easy to transform so-called hermaphrodites or amphibians from the enemies of nationalist pedagogues to the heroes of multicultural fantasies. But in a world of national hierarchies, identity cards, and national ascription, many were simply talking back to nationalists in nationalist terms. The more states and nationalist movements obsessed over fixing and ranking national communities, making such affiliation the basis for citizenship and social rights, the more individuals stood to gain by being able to move easily between those communities.

Transnationalism and Indifference

The emerging field of transnational history intersects with the project of historicizing national indifference, in that both reflect a movement to uncover the blind spots of national history.⁷¹ The field of transnational history builds upon many intellectual neighbors and predecessors that have contributed to the gradual decentering of the nation-state in historical analysis, including comparative history, *histoire croisée*, transfer history, postcolonial studies, international history, Atlantic history, and global history.⁷² For historians of east central Europe, the appeal of transnational history is almost self-evident, since transnationality has defined the mod-

70. On a desire for “normality” after World War II, see Richard Bessel and Dirk Schumann, eds., *Life after Death: Approaches to a Cultural and Social History of Europe during the 1940s and 1950s* (New York, 2003).

71. On the theoretical concerns of transnationalism, see in particular Jürgen Osterhammel and Sebastian Conrad, eds., *Das Kaiserreich Transnational: Deutschland in der Welt, 1871–1914* (Göttingen, 2004); Thomas Bender, ed., *Rethinking America in a Global Age* (Berkeley, 2002); Philipp Ther, “Beyond the Nation: The Relational Basis of a Comparative History of Germany and Europe,” *Central European History* 36, no. 1 (2003): 45–73; Ute Frevert, “Europeanizing Germany’s Twentieth Century,” *History and Memory: Studies in Representation of the Past* 17, no. 1/2 (Fall 2005): 87–116; Patricia Clavin, “Defining Transnationalism,” *Contemporary European History* 14, no. 4 (November 2005): 421–39; David Blackburn, “Europeanizing German History: A Comment,” *Bulletin of the German Historical Institute* 36 (Spring 2005): 25–32.

72. On *histoire croisée* and transfer history, see Michel Espagne, *Les transferts culturels franco-allemands* (Paris, 1999); Bénédicte Zimmermann and Michael Werner, eds., *De la comparaison à l’histoire croisée* (Paris, 2004). For a discussion of the differences between *histoire croisée* and cultural transfer, see Haupt and Kocka, “Comparative History,” 31–33. For an introduction to global history in theory and practice, see Bruce Mazlish and Akira Iriye, eds., *The Global History Reader* (New York, 2005).

ern history of eastern Europe. In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, eastern Europe has been an ample source of migrants and refugees, a source of raw materials and a market for European goods, occupied by several different regimes, and part of several different empires and states. Countless individuals who lived between Germany and Russia spoke more than one language, were citizens of more than one state, and identified with more than one national community over the course of their own lifetimes. Many historians of east central Europe have therefore long been thinking transnationally about topics such as empire, borderlands, occupations, migration, and ethnic cleansing.

Transnational history also seems to offer the seductive possibility of writing about something *other* than nationalism—the ideas, people, goods, and international organizations that circulated in eastern Europe with little attention to the borders of nation-states. In this sense, transnational history appears to offer a refreshing alternative to the concept of national indifference.⁷³ After all, while claiming to subvert or challenge national categories, national indifference ultimately puts the nation right back at the center of the agenda, albeit in a negative form. Transnational history, by contrast, has the potential to offer a new set of thematic concerns and a new window on old concerns.

But transnational history also carries the danger of assuming the nation as its starting point.⁷⁴ The concept of national indifference can actually help historians to avoid this pitfall. Challenging the nationalist assumptions that shape the history and memory of Europe will require more than simply changing scales or seeking out institutions, identities, or processes that appear to float above, below, or across the borders of nation-states (migration, trade, empire, tourism, religion, localism, and regionalism, to name a few). In fact, it will be challenging to write transnational histories that do not presume the existence of national collectives unless we first take national indifference seriously.

Historians of modern Germany, for example, have expressed growing interest in the history of Germany's fraught relations with eastern Europe and in the history of Germans in the east. This *Drang nach Osten* in German historiography has several sources. In addition to a broader interest in transnational history, it reflects efforts to situate the Holocaust more deeply in its east European context.⁷⁵ Thanks to the influence of colonial and postcolonial studies, Germanists have also begun to confront Germany's longer-term imperialist agenda in east central Europe. Eastern

73. For an example of a history that challenges national frameworks by writing the history of "something else," see Alison Fleig Frank, *Oil Empire: Visions of Prosperity in Austrian Galicia* (Cambridge, Mass., 2005).

74. On the dangers of transnational history, see C. A. Bayly, Sven Beckert, Matthew Connelly, Isabel Hofmeyr, Wendy Kozol, and Patricia Seed, "AHR Conversation: On Transnational History," *American Historical Review* 111, no. 5 (December 2006): 1442.

75. See, for example, Omer Bartov, "Eastern Europe as the Site of Genocide," *Journal of Modern History* 80, no. 3 (September 2008): 557–93; Timothy Snyder, "Holocaust: The Ignored Reality," *New York Review of Books* 56, no. 12 (16 July 2009).

Europe, David Blackbourn has argued, is “Germany’s India or Algeria” and is ripe for transnational study.⁷⁶ Looking eastward has produced fresh perspectives on the transnational dimensions of German history, on the shifting contours of German nationalism and citizenship, and on the origins and dynamics of Nazi racial politics.

But the turn eastward also has its pitfalls. Namely, it is a mistake to assume that German-speakers in modern east central Europe were a bounded, clearly identified group, that they had common “German” interests, that they necessarily oppressed or dominated their Slavic neighbors or that they even saw themselves as different from those neighbors. We cannot write history from multiple “sides” without questioning how those “sides” were first constituted.⁷⁷ By raising the fundamental question of who was a German and who was a Slav, the concept of national indifference can help historians to write transnational histories that successfully challenge nationalist assumptions.

The concept of national indifference might also serve as a useful tool in migration studies. Debates about the experiences of migrants could be reconceptualized using the concept of national indifference rather than such terms as *assimilation*, *acculturation*, or *hybridity* that assume preexisting national loyalties and coherent group identities. In addition, historians could examine how experiences of migration and displacement served to accentuate or eradicate national indifference. Recent scholarship on displacement in Europe after World War II reflects this approach, combining a transnational methodology with attention to national indifference. Much of this research demonstrates that experiences of displacement actually furthered the nationalization of east European populations, sometimes through official categorization by international relief organizations, which organized refugees along national lines in order to facilitate repatriation.⁷⁸ In 1951, Hannah Arendt observed that “not a single group of refugees or Displaced Persons has failed to develop a fierce, violent,

76. See Blackbourn, “Europeanizing German History,” 25–32. On Germany in the east, see Vejas G. Liulevicius, *War Land on the Eastern Front: Culture, National Identity and German Occupation in World War I* (Cambridge, Eng., 2000); Liulevicius, *The German Myth of the East: 1800 to the Present* (Oxford, 2009); Isabel Hull, *Absolute Destruction: Military Culture and the Practices of War in Imperial Germany* (Ithaca, 2005); Annemarie Sammartino, *The Impossible Border: Germany, Migration, and the East, 1914–1922* (Ithaca, 2010); Harvey, *Women and the Nazi East*; Mazower, *Hitler’s Empire*; Lora Wildenthal, *German Women for Empire, 1884–1945* (Durham, 2001).

77. For more on the turn eastward in German history, see Tara Zahra, “Looking East: East Central European ‘Borderlands’ in German History and Historiography,” *History Compass* 3, no. 1 (January 2005): 1–23.

78. On the nationalization of displaced persons and refugees, see Avinoam J. Patt, *Finding Home and Homeland: Jewish Youth and Zionism in the Aftermath of the Holocaust* (Detroit, 2009); Atina Grossmann, *Jews, Germans, and Allies: Close Encounters in Occupied Germany* (Princeton, 2007); Pamela Ballinger, “Borders of the Nation, Borders of Citizenship: Italian Repatriation and the Definition of National Identity after World War II,” *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 49, no. 3 (July 2007): 713–41; Wolfgang Jacobsmeier, *Vom Zwangsarbeiter zum heimatlosen Ausländer: Die Displaced Persons in Westdeutschland 1945–51* (Göttingen, 1985); Liisa Malkki, *Purity and Exile: Violence, Memory, and National Cosmology among Hutu Refugees in Tanzania* (Chicago, 1995); Tara Zahra, “Lost Children: Displace-

group consciousness and to clamor for rights as—and only as—Poles or Jews or Germans, etc.”⁷⁹ Postwar refugees were responding to their own experiences of persecution and displacement during World War II as well as to the legal structures created by the Allies after the war. Individual rights to asylum, to repatriation or resettlement abroad, and to food and housing were all distributed hierarchically based on nationality, in spite of the universalizing discourse of “human rights.”

But national indeterminacy and imposture did not disappear in Europe’s Displaced Persons’ camps. Many refugees deliberately obscured or falsified their nationality in order to escape forcible repatriation to the Soviet Union, evade imprisonment for collaboration with the Nazis, or simply to gain a favored status for emigration schemes, housing, or food rations. In the early 1950s, for example, Jewish agencies complained that many Jewish refugees from Poland or Romania in postwar Austria were forced to pose as Sudeten Germans in order to expedite their requests for citizenship, housing, and social rights, due to ongoing antisemitism in Austrian society. Legions of Soviet citizens who wished to escape forcible repatriation meanwhile posed as Poles in Europe’s postwar displaced person camps, sometimes with a wink and a nod from sympathetic translators and Allied authorities.⁸⁰ Government officials in Austria were also suspicious of the national loyalties of expellees. A 1947 memo from the Austrian Ministry of Interior cautioned, “It is not always easy for the Austrian authorities to decide in individual cases if they are dealing with an ethnic German or an ethnic Slovene from Yugoslavia, because both the Volksdeutsche and the Slovenes speak both languages equally well, or equally poorly, and they can therefore claim to be Germans or Slovenes according to their own needs.”⁸¹

National ambiguity also confounded the international humanitarian workers faced with unaccompanied displaced children after World War II. In order to classify children according to their “correct” nationality, they resorted to extensive interviews with so-called lost children who had forgotten their own names and origins. One United Nations’ social worker elaborated in a 1946 report:

The question of nationality is most perplexing in the cases of children coming from Silesia because of the mixed German and Polish population in that area before the war. In the absence of identity papers less dependable factors must be relied upon in determining nationality. . . . Our most skillful interviewers report that the children’s psychological reac-

ment, Family and Nation in Postwar Europe,” *Journal of Modern History* 81, no. 1 (March 2009): 45–86.

79. Hannah Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (New York, 1951), 292.

80. Memorandum of Agudas Israel, 25 June 1953, Carton 11, 12U-34, Bundesministerium des Innern, Archiv der Republik, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Vienna. On Soviet displaced persons and national imposture, see Andrew Janco, “The Soviet Refugees in Postwar Europe and the Cold War, 1945–51” (PhD diss., University of Chicago, 2010).

81. “Das Problem der D.P.s in Österreich,” 29 April 1947, 5, Carton 35, II-pol 1947, Bundesministerium für auswärtige Angelegenheiten, Archive der Republik, Österreichisches Staatsarchiv, Vienna.

tions to questions about nationality are significant. The unquestionably German child usually replies freely and promptly. The response of the non-German child, though he says he is German, is often characterized by embarrassment, hesitation, confusion, or frantic appeal to a member of the staff for help in making reply.⁸²

No one considered the possibility that a Silesian child might have been genuinely confused about his or her national affiliation. Only in exceptional cases was the ambiguity of national belonging officially recognized, as in Italy, where International Refugee Organization officials created the category of "Undetermined Venezia Giulians" to designate refugees in Italy from Venezia Giulia with indeterminate national loyalties. Ballinger argues that the work of classification in postwar refugee camps suggests that the history of national indeterminacy and indifference in east central Europe did not simply end with ethnic cleansing in 1945.⁸³ This research on postwar displacement also illustrates the ways in which the history of national indifference intersects with the history of migration, as the movement of people across borders exposed the limits of nationalization and prompted state authorities to confront and classify nationally indifferent populations. Ethnic cleansing in eastern Europe was ultimately an effort to eradicate national indifference as much as an attempt to eliminate national minorities.

National indifference has a long and colorful history in modern Europe. It appeared on the scene as an imagined noncommunity in the mid-nineteenth century, called into being by nationalists themselves through their own paranoia. Like the imagined community of the nation, the imagined noncommunity of the nationally indifferent is best understood in its local contexts, since both its form and meaning transformed across time and space. Indifference has its own histories. But the concept of national indifference may ultimately be most productive as a starting point for scholarly research rather than as a peculiarity or exception requiring explanation. Rather than assuming that people in Europe belonged to nations, perhaps we should assume indifference and investigate how and why people allied themselves politically, culturally, and socially from the ground up.

More broadly, the study of indifference offers a promising strategy for problematizing preconceived relationships between individual subjectivity and collective affiliation. Although I have focused on national indifference in east central Europe, political indifference, gender indifference, class indifference, and religious indifference may also prove fruitful categories for scholars interested in the history of subjectivity, loyalty, and classification. Indifference may also help social and cultural historians to better integrate the history of individuals who seem to be on the margins of elite politics into their analysis. Indifference, far from being the binary

82. Removal of Children (Polish) from the St. Joseph's Kinderheim, 14 October 1946, File 16, S-0437- 0013, United Nations Archive, New York; see also W. C. Huyssoon, "Who Is This Child," Sample of an Interview with an Unaccompanied Child, File 11, S-0437- 0013, United Nations Archive.

83. Ballinger, "Borders of the Nation," 713–41.

opposite of political engagement, a reflection of popular ignorance, or a premodern relic, was often a response to modern mass politics. As historians, we cannot be indifferent to the nation-state and its impact on modern history. But we can attempt to capture those moments when its grip on both the individual and society was less than absolute. In the process, perhaps we can finally rescue the citizens of Habsburg central Europe from the “prison of nations” once and for all.